

B2B SALES ESSENTIALS

B2B Sales Essentials — Level 1 — Day 3: Discovery in B2B: Business Problems and the Cost of Doing Nothing

Study guide · Self-study

Level 1 · Day 3: Discovery in B2B: Business Problems and the Cost of Doing Nothing

How to Use This Guide

This is Day 3 of your Level 1 self-study series. You work through it alone, at your own pace. Read a section, then stop and do the small exercise before moving on. The exercises are short by design, because discovery is a skill you build by speaking, not by reading.

You have already covered research and first contact on Days 1 and 2. Today you go deeper: what to ask once a conversation is under way, and how to hear the business problem behind the first answer.

Write your answers in your own words. The model answers at the end are examples, not scripts. Your wording should sound like you.

One habit to build from today: keep a simple discovery log. One line per real conversation. The question you asked, what you heard, what you did with it. By Day 5 you will have a record of your own learning.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the four-rung question ladder (situation, problem, impact, need) and why the impact rung matters most.

Attitude: You will treat discovery as listening with a purpose, not as a polite pause before your pitch.

Skill: You will ask open how and what questions that surface a client's business problem and what it costs them to leave it unsolved.

Upskill: You will use at least three of these questions in real conversations and record what changed in your next step because of what you heard.

Why Clients Answer Only the Questions You Ask

A B2B client rarely volunteers the real problem. They are busy, they have been sold to before, and they have no reason to hand you information that makes them feel exposed. So they answer exactly what you ask, and nothing more.

This is the rookie mistake: believing that selling means talking. New sellers fill the space with product facts, and the client politely waits for it to end. The seller who asks a better question learns what the business actually needs. That seller becomes useful.

Think about how a buyer decides what to tell you. Most of the time they are running on fast, automatic judgment: is this person safe, is this relevant, is this worth my minutes? A closed question ("Do you need anything else?") fits that fast mode perfectly. It asks for almost no thought, so it gets almost no information. An open how or what question asks the client to slow down and explain. That small effort is where the useful detail lives.

There is a second reason. People protect themselves from being judged. A question that sounds like an accusation puts the client on the defensive, and defensive people share less. A question that invites them to describe their situation makes them the expert. Most people are glad to explain their own work when the asking is genuine.

Ask How and What, Not Yes or No

Chris Voss, a former FBI hostage negotiator, recommends calibrated questions: open questions beginning with how or what that get the other side talking and thinking rather than simply agreeing (Voss & Raz, 2016). In B2B discovery they do one job: they hand the conversation to the client.

Compare these pairs.

- "Are you happy with your supplier?" becomes "How is your current supplier working out for this kind of order?"
- "Is delivery important?" becomes "What does delivery need to look like for this project?"
- "Do you have budget?" becomes "How are you planning to fund this work?"
- The closed version gets a yes, a no, or a shrug. The open version gets a sentence you can work with, and often a second sentence the client did not plan to say.
- One caution about the word why. "Why did you choose the other supplier?" is open, but it can sound like a challenge, and clients hear judgment in it. Ask "What made that supplier a good fit for that job?" instead. Same information, no defense.
- Practice example: A client says their last order arrived a week late. Instead of "Why did that happen?", ask "What did the delay affect on your side?" The client explains that two crews stood idle and a handover slipped. You now know what lateness costs them, in their words.

> **NOTES**
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> If a client gives a one-word answer, do not repeat the question louder. Widen it: "What's coming up for you in the next few weeks?"

The Question Ladder: From Situation to Need

The question ladder is a four-rung structure adapted from Neil Rackham's SPIN questioning (Rackham, 1988). You climb it in order: situation, problem, impact, need. Each rung depends on the one below it.

Situation: the facts. "What's the project? What stage are you at?" Keep this short. Clients tire of being interviewed about things you could have researched.

Problem: what is hard. "What's been the biggest headache so far?" This is where dissatisfaction becomes sayable.

Impact: what the problem costs. "What happens if that slips?" Rackham's research on larger sales found that successful sellers asked far more questions about the consequences of problems than weaker performers did. This is the rung most new sellers skip, and it is the one that changes the deal.

Need: what would help. "What would make this easier right now?" The client starts describing the outcome they want, in their own words.

Why does impact work? Because a problem the client has not priced stays small in their mind. Naming the consequence makes it real. You are not inflating it. You are asking the client to do the arithmetic they have been avoiding.

Practice example: A logistics client mentions that invoice errors are "a bit annoying." You ask what happens when an invoice is wrong. The client says each one takes two people half a day to fix, and their finance team has started questioning the whole contract. The problem just became a business problem.

The Cost of Doing Nothing

Many deals are lost to delay rather than to a competitor. The client decides to wait, and waiting feels free. It rarely is.

Your job in discovery is to help the client see what genuinely changes if the decision is postponed. That may be a deadline they have already told you about, a cost that keeps accruing, a window that closes, or a risk that grows. It is also honest to conclude that waiting is fine. If nothing changes by waiting, say so, and you will be trusted more, not less.

This connects to how people weigh decisions. Losses tend to feel sharper than equivalent gains, so a client who sees only the price of acting will hesitate, while the same client who sees what inaction costs them can decide (Kahneman & Tversky, 1979). Use this honestly: with the client's own numbers and their own stated deadline, never with invented urgency.

Timing, headcount and pressure are the three areas where B2B problems usually hide. Ask what the next milestone is, how many people are working on it, and what the pressure is coming from. Then ask what happens if the milestone slips.

Practice example: A software client says the migration can wait until next year. You ask what happens to the two teams still on the old system in the meantime. The client pauses, then says support costs rise every quarter they stay. That is the cost of doing nothing, in their words, not yours.

Asking About Money Without Asking About Budget

Direct budget questions usually fail. "What's your budget?" invites either a number that is too low, a refusal, or a guess. It also puts the client in a defensive position early, before they trust you.

Ask about financial impact indirectly instead. Questions like "How does this get funded?" or "What does a problem like this cost you over a quarter?" let the client describe money in their own frame. You learn the size, the source and the timing without an interrogation.

This matters because budget is often not fixed. It moves when the business case is strong enough. Your discovery is what builds that case. You will go deeper into pricing conversations on Day 4.

> **NOTES**
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> Never state a figure the client has not given you. If you need a number to work with, say it is your assumption and check it with them.

Listening That Proves You Heard

Questions are half the skill. The other half is what you do with the answer.

Slow down. Let a pause sit after the client finishes. Most people add their most useful sentence right after the silence.

Mirror. Repeat the client's last few words as a question: "Penalty clause?" It invites them to keep going, and it proves you were paying attention.

Summarize. "So the units need to be on site by the 15th, or you carry the penalty." A short summary lets the client correct you, and corrections are gold.

Write it down in the client's words. Then use it in the next conversation. Using what you heard is the strongest proof that you listened, and it builds the kind of trust that survives a mistake later.

Practice example: A client mentions "the audit in March" in passing. You note it. On your next call you ask how the audit preparation is going. The client is surprised you remembered, and tells you the real reason the project date cannot move.

Apply It in Your Role

You are new, so keep this small and doable.

On research and preparation: before a call, write two situation questions and one impact question. That is enough.

On live calls: aim to ask more than you tell. If you are shadowing a colleague, count their questions and note which ones produced the longest answers.

On email and messages: replace "Do you have any needs?" with one specific open question tied to something you read about their business.

In your discovery log: after each real conversation, write the question, the answer, and the next step you took because of it. If the answer changed nothing, note that too. A question that does not change what you do is just conversation.

> **NOTES**
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> You do not need a large pipeline to practice. Three conversations with real clients, even short ones, are enough for this week.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you read the model answers. Keep them in your own voice.

1. A client says, "We're fine with our current supplier." What is your next question?

2. A client mentions that a project is "a bit behind." What impact question do you ask?

3. You want to know how the client will fund the work, without asking "What's your budget?" What do you say?

4. The client gives a one-word answer to your question. What do you do next?

5. Write a question you commonly ask that starts with why. Rewrite it to start with what or how.

> **NOTES**
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> If one of these stumps you, reread the question ladder section above before you write. Your answer should sound like you, not like the guide.

Key Takeaways

- Clients answer the questions you ask, and nothing more. Better questions are the skill.
- Use how and what questions. Yes or no questions end conversations.
- Climb the ladder in order: situation, problem, impact, need. Do not skip impact.
- The cost of doing nothing is often the real competitor. Help the client see it honestly.
- Ask about money indirectly: how it gets funded, what the problem costs.
- Slow down, mirror, summarize, and write it down in the client's words.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Choose one option for each.

1. Which question is a calibrated question?

   A. "Do you need anything else for this order?"
   B. "What happens on your side if the delivery slips?"
   C. "Is price important to you?"
   D. "Are you happy with your current supplier?"

2. In the question ladder, which rung do new sellers most often skip?

   A. Situation
   B. Problem
   C. Impact
   D. Need

3. Why do direct budget questions often fail early in a B2B conversation?

   A. Clients never know their budget
   B. They put the client on the defensive before trust is built
   C. Budget is always fixed and cannot change
   D. They take too long to ask

4. A client says, "We can wait until next year." What is the most useful next question?
   A. "Would you like me to send a proposal anyway?"
   B. "Is cost the only thing holding you back?"
   C. "What changes for your team if this stays as it is for another year?"
   D. "Can I call you next year?"
5. A client answers your question with one word. What is the best response?
   A. Repeat the same question more slowly
   B. Move on to your product presentation
   C. Widen the question and give the client room to explain
   D. Answer the question for them to save time

Upskill Challenge

Complete this before Day 4.

Use at least three how or what questions with real clients. Include at least one impact question, such as "What happens if...?" or "What does that cost you?"

Record each one in your discovery log:

Question asked: ____

What I heard (in the client's words): ____

What I did next because of it: ____

Second question: ____

What I heard: ____

What I did next: ____

Third question: ____

What I heard: ____

What I did next: ____

At the end, write one line on which question produced the most useful answer and why you think it did: ____

> **NOTES**
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> If you only get one real conversation this week, use all three questions in it. One good conversation is enough to learn from. If you are unsure how to word a question, reread the How and What section before the conversation.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. What matters is the principle behind each one.

1. "What would a supplier have to do to be worth switching for?" The principle: instead of arguing with "we're fine," ask what better would look like. The client explains their criteria, and you learn something you could never have guessed.

2. "What does being behind affect downstream?" The principle: impact questions turn a vague status into a specific cost, using the client's own situation.

3. "How does work like this usually get funded on your side?" The principle: the client describes money in their own frame, without a defensive budget question.

4. Widen it. "What's coming up for you over the next few weeks?" The principle: a one-word answer usually means the question was too narrow or too early, not that the client has nothing to say.

5. "Why didn't you order from us?" becomes "What would have made us the right choice for that order?" The principle: what and how ask for the same information without putting the client on the defensive.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. It is an open how or what question that invites the client to explain, not just agree.
- 2. C. Impact is where the client states what the problem costs, and it is the rung most often rushed past.
- 3. B. An early budget question feels like an interrogation and narrows what the client will share.
- 4. C. It invites the client to describe the cost of inaction in their own words, honestly.
- 5. C. Widening the question gives the client room, while repeating it or answering for them closes the conversation down.

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